

AP

BIDING HIS TIME Bilawal Bhutto Zardari of PPP has used his position as foreign minister to build international contacts for the future

BEING THE JUNIOR PARTNER IN THE COALITION, PPP HAS LUCKED OUT. IT HAS USED THIS TIME TO STRENGTHEN ITS HOLD ON SINDH. ITS ABSENCE IN THE ECONOMIC MINISTRIES HAS SAVED IT FROM PUBLIC IRE

as being too directly involved in matters of governance, especially at a time when public anger is rising.

For his part, and despite being under pressure, Khan continues to play his cards as well as any opportunistic populist leader. He forced his allied governments in the provinces of Punjab and Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa (KP) to dissolve the assemblies to force elections that the federal government seemed reluctant to hold. This is because the PDM government fears that the harsh economic measures it has been forced to implement under the International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme may unleash a wave of anger against it at the polls.

Khan is counting on this as well as the fact that Punjab and KP comprise almost 68 per cent of the total seats in the National Assembly. Recently, the main parliamentarians of the smaller Pakistan Muslim League-Quaid (PML-Q), including former chief minister Pervaiz Elahi and his son Moonis Elahi, jumped ship to join the PTI. The elder Elahi, whom Khan once dubbed the "biggest dacoit of Pakistan", was even made president of PTI. With a wave in Khan's favour, that would almost guarantee that PTI forms the next federal government as well as in the two important provinces.

Currently, however, a fresh constitutional crisis is brewing, since elections are supposed to be held within 90 days of the assemblies being dissolved. The Supreme Court (SC), too, has ordered the same. Having two provincial elections separately from the general election will be unprecedented in Pakistan. The government is arguing that it will lead to total confusion, since the results of the census currently underway, which could potentially redraw constituencies, will not be known until after the 90-day deadline. Had their governments completed their terms, elections in the two provinces as well as at the federal level would not have been due until October, and could have been held on the basis of the new census.

As of now, the defence ministry has said that it cannot provide army personnel for election duty, given the current security situation. The police, too, has told the Election Commission that, given the high level of security threats, it cannot guarantee foolproof security by itself. While politicians claim to be gearing up for the two provincial elections, it is not at all clear that the elections will, in fact, be held on time. All sides are spending sleepless nights thinking how the provincial elections can be postponed in the face of the SC's orders.

In fact, there is some resentment, within the PML-N in particular, about the role of the judiciary, which has shown itself to be completely polarised. PML-N senior vice president Maryam Nawaz has openly accused former SC chief justices of having played a dirty game to help engineer her father, former prime minister Nawaz Sharif's, disqualification and